The Municipal Project Brief

Reading 4 of 4: What the class is building, what is settled and what is open

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Your starting assignment

You are a department head, agency leader, civic representative or partner in the fictional City and County of East Detroit, Colorado, in 2030. The city has 382,417 residents, twenty provisional neighborhoods, a large and unevenly developed territory, and major needs in housing, water, transit, benefits, address records, schools, safety and community facilities.

The assignment: write the specification for a city-county version of Estonia's digital government. In Estonia, government agencies keep their own records and exchange data through a shared, secure layer called X-tee, under agreements between the organizations involved (Reading 2 and the Directory explain how it works). The class will specify how East Detroit's departments and outside agencies could do the same: which records they hold, what they would share and on what terms, who runs the exchange, how residents are protected, and which services come first.

The city-county exists. **The spec is unwritten.** No digital identity, app, procurement, vendor, cloud platform, data exchange, governance board or first service has been approved. Your job is to help establish the facts, develop the spec and its implementation plan, and negotiate with other agencies to carry it out.

As in the other readings, **SCENARIO** marks facts the course has created, **REAL REFERENCE** marks real laws and organizations, and **OPEN** marks choices the class makes.

What is settled and what is open

Settled for the exercise (SCENARIO)

1. East Detroit exists as a consolidated city-county and is coping with rapid growth. The class starts from that point.
2. Its residents and services are diverse. The demographics and neighborhoods in Reading 1 are planning assumptions that teams can question. They are not real Census estimates.
3. The city-county has operating city and county departments and elected leaders. The **City Housing Division** and the independent **East Detroit Regional Housing Authority** both exist.
4. Its major civic and cultural institutions are the anchors described in Reading 1: The Hangar at Space Center, the Denver Fawns, the Colorado Apex, the Denver Pilots at Aerotropolis Park, EDPAC and the East Detroit Health System.
5. Some outside bodies are independent: schools, RTD, water providers, airport owners and operators, state and federal agencies, and other jurisdictions. They may agree to joint work, refuse it or set conditions.

The class controls every other choice, within the scenario's basic facts about geography, population and status.

Open for the class (OPEN)

- The exact county boundary and the neighborhood boundaries
- The local charter and how residents are represented
- Which services to deliver first, and how
- Water financing
- Partnerships with outside agencies
- How information is handled and shared
- Technology and procurement
- The form, delegated powers and priority rules of any shared service, including any agreement between the two housing institutions
- Funding, ownership and digital systems for the civic and cultural anchors

Ideas from earlier drafts, open for debate

Earlier drafts of this project presented the following as adopted. They are not. Each is an example to debate, change or reject:

- ED-Core digital identity and ED-Wallet
- "Once only" as a fixed municipal law
- Universal zero-knowledge YES/NO data APIs
- Automated housing approvals and income checks
- Automatic school enrollment triggers or seats
- RTD fare integration
- Mandatory telemetry for parks access
- A 48-hour limit for provisional GIS records
- 60-minute emergency access tokens
- Automatic historic preservation holds
- Digital voting on public art
- Digital onboarding through libraries
- Vendor procurement and cloud hosting choices
- A phased platform launch
- A specific board size and membership

Earlier drafts also implied 100% voucher uptake, uniform student assignment and "zero burden" outcomes. None of these had implementation evidence behind them.

The three stages of the project

The project has three stages. The goal is fixed (an Estonia-style spec), but no particular product, platform or governance design is assumed to be the answer.

Stage A: Establish the basis

Find out the city-county's duties, needs, existing assets, costs, resident cases and limits of authority. Department and agency heads identify priorities and dependencies, and may challenge the city's starting assumptions.

Your work in this stage:

- Name the community need or service problem your role sees.
- Identify the resident or worker who experiences it, and the neighborhood or neighborhoods where it matters.
- Separate what East Detroit already provides in the scenario, what another agency actually controls, and what is unknown.
- State the authority, money, staff, information, facilities and partners your role would need.

Stage B: Develop an implementation plan

Choose service priorities, decision-makers, governance or procurement options, first working demonstrations, financing, staffing, technical and data dependencies, review routes and sequence. The instructor turns agreed decisions into a draft implementation specification during a shared build.

Your work in this stage:

- Propose what to do first, and why.
- State the policy decision, who can authorize it, how the work would run, how it is paid for, what must be built or bought, and what users should see.
- Name an alternative you considered, and how you would test the result.
- Choose the level of technology and partnership you can justify. You do not have to accept the ED-Core and ED-Wallet design from earlier drafts.

Stage C: Coordinate stakeholders

Every internal city-county department takes part in the process, though its leaders can question policy, feasibility and sequence. External partners may accept, negotiate terms or refuse. A refusal changes the service model and the plan; it is not a failure to participate.

Your work in this stage:

- Identify which other departments or outside organizations must take part.
- Request their consent or an agreement.
- If they decline, record their reason and revise the plan.
- If they take part only under conditions, record the conditions in the decision record.

- Make sure someone is responsible for complaints, corrections, appeals and ending an arrangement that is not working.

What the class produces

- A baseline register
- Named owners for each stakeholder relationship
- A map of services and who has authority over them
- Proposed charter provisions or agreements where needed
- A log of decisions and dissents
- An implementation plan
- One or more demonstrations or tests of how a service actually behaves

Choose what you will own

Each student owns one entry: a city-county department, an outside agency or a resident group. Use the **Directory of Departments and Agencies** to find your area, and claim it on the **Sign-up Sheet**. There are 27 entries, more than there are students. **The instructor speaks for every entry nobody claims.**

Table 1. Who owns the spec

Group	Entries	Status
City-county departments	D-01 to D-15	Must take part
Outside agencies	A-01 to A-08: school district, library district, water and sewer authority, RTD, State human services and IT, Regional Housing Authority, County Court, Health and Hospital Authority	Always represented; may refuse to join
Optional outside agency	A-09: East Detroit Health System	Takes part only if a student claims it
Resident groups	R-01 to R-03	Test the spec; always represented

Students are encouraged to take outside agencies and resident groups. Outside agencies decide whether to join the exchange, so they shape the spec as much as any department.

City-county departments take part because East Detroit has assigned them to. Their owners can still contest details, budgets, feasibility, legal authority and sequence. Outside agencies choose whether to take part, and on what terms. Either outcome gives the class real consequences to work through. A department head can bring several proposed decisions, and students may challenge each other's proposals.

Four governance decisions to make explicit

Authority. Which public body can approve a shared service, adopt standards, spend public money, invite a partner and stop a harmful practice? Is it an existing city-county function, a new authority, an intergovernmental agreement, a nonprofit, or a combination? Who can overrule whom?

Ownership and operations. Who controls the domain name, cloud or hosting accounts, source code, contracts, records and any analysis derived from them? Who actually answers users, keeps service hours, patches systems, handles complaints and takes over if a vendor fails? Separate each asset and each responsibility.

Information. For every exchange of information, identify the sender, the receiver, the purpose, the fields, the legal or fictional authority, the consent or notice, how long it is kept, who corrects it, who reviews it, how incidents are handled, and how optional sharing can be revoked. “Once only,” ED-Wallet, zero-knowledge APIs and automated referrals are options, not policy.

Money and incentives. Compare general appropriations, agency contributions, user fees, developer fees, land-value mechanisms, grants, special districts and contract revenue. Explain who pays, who benefits, and what happens if expected revenue does not arrive.

Choosing the first service

The first service is chosen on evidence and through negotiation; the course does not prescribe one. Candidates include:

- Correcting addresses across new parcels
- Permits
- Emergency housing and tenant assistance
- Intake for county-administered food or cash programs
- Transit access
- Recreation access
- Connections to schools
- Library and community support
- Emergency routing
- Public art or venue services

Any of these may be chosen or rejected. A first launch can be one complete, useful transaction, several connected touchpoints, or a process used only by staff, as long as the class can justify it.

For each candidate service, ask:

- Which law or simulated authority controls the decision?
- Which agency handles complaints, review and appeals?
- What happens if the other agency is offline, declines to take part, or supplies a wrong record?

- What test would reveal a harmful design, including for a resident who has no phone or whose address is disputed?

Negotiating with independent agencies

A strong partner agreement states:

- Scope and legal basis
- The parties
- Service levels
- Data fields and permitted uses
- Who corrects records
- How incidents are handled
- Payment
- Limits on using data for training or resale
- Public transparency
- Audit rights
- How either party can revoke or exit
- Duties during a transition

A memorandum of understanding (MOU) is enough when it only coordinates intentions. Duties that must be enforceable need the right legal instrument. Record negotiations in the class decision record.

Example: connecting to schools. The city wants residents who register a move to be offered a school enrollment referral. The school district could agree to a secure address-check service; agree only to provide fixed referral information; demand funding and manual review; or refuse. City GIS can still keep a municipal address record, but it cannot make the school's binding enrollment decision without the district.

Example: regional transit. RTD might offer a timetable or fare exchange, accept a limited pilot, or decline. The city can still publish route information or fund a separate, legally supported mobility program. A rail hub in the scenario does not require RTD to connect its ticketing systems.

Questions every department head should answer

1. Which public problem and resident experience should the first service address, and in which neighborhoods? Which household does it affect?
2. Which problem will your department own?
3. What is currently delivered by the city-county, by the state through county administration, or by another public body? Which powers does East Detroit have, and which sit elsewhere?
4. Who can approve policy, allocate resources, authorize access, correct records, hear disputes and stop a harmful launch?
5. Which partners are indispensable, what deal must be struck before launch, and what happens if a partner refuses to join?

6. What will residents, frontline staff, reviewers and elected officials see when the service runs, both when a case succeeds and when it fails?
7. How will we know whether the chosen arrangement works better, and whom might it leave out?

What happens in class

Students who own a role present their proposals and challenge each other's assumptions. The class compares conflicting requirements and decides what must be tested.

The instructor then builds or revises a working implementation model with AI in front of the class. The output might be a service diagram, a screen, a data exchange, a staff work queue, a cost model or a test of an agreement. Each department may bring several decisions and competing strategies, and every choice in the model can be traced to who proposed it.

A screen or workflow the AI generates shows that an arrangement can be simulated. It does not show that its rules or funding have been adopted.

The record keeps who proposed what, what the group chose, who dissented and what changed when the class tried it. A rejected connection, a contested rule or a missed case is a useful result. Earlier versions stay in the record so the class can return to them.

You do not need unanimous agreement to make progress. Keep disagreements, refusals and missing information in the record. Where a decision is still contested, the class can test more than one path.

What to bring to the first session

- Your entry and its service problem, with one specific resident case
- The records your entry holds that others would need, and what it needs from others
- The decision you propose, and the real or fictional authority it depends on
- A second option and its trade-off
- At least one internal dependency, and one outside organization that might accept, negotiate or refuse
- What you expect to see if your plan works, including a failure or exception case

Label your sources. Mark real facts as **REAL REFERENCE**, facts created for the course as **SCENARIO**, and unresolved choices as **OPEN**. Do not present fictional demographics, new ZIP codes, governance powers or data agreements as existing Colorado law.

Where to find the background

- **Reading 1: Welcome to East Detroit** describes the city, its people, neighborhoods, anchor institutions and the six test households.
- **Reading 2: How East Detroit Is Governed** explains who holds authority, the Colorado legal setting and the Michigan comparisons.

- **Reading 3: Housing** documents the Detroit and Home Forward cases behind East Detroit's two housing institutions.
- **Sign-up Sheet** and **Directory of Departments and Agencies** list every entry, what it is responsible for, and where to start.